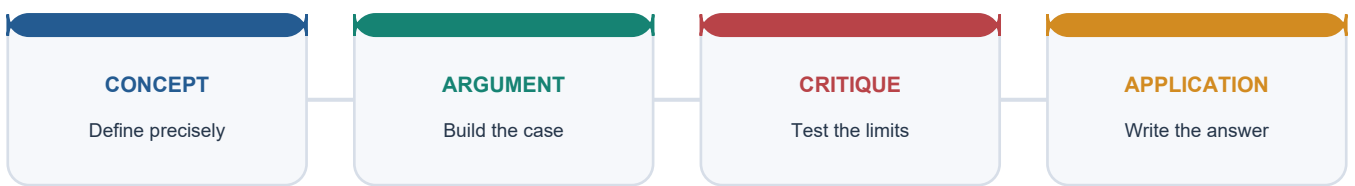


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Yoga - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

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Yoga - Solved Practice Workbook

How to use this workbook. Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed independently for each question from a randomised draw, so no rotation or predictable sequence can be exploited. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The solved previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.

Contents. 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial drills, then 8 solved previous-year questions - seven primary-owned by syllabus item 17 and one routed here because Yoga's proof of God is the comparative subject under examination - followed by six original solved Mains models at 2 x 10, 2 x 15 and 2 x 20 marks.

Declared answer bands. 10 marks: 150-200 words. 15 marks: 250-300 words. 20 marks: 340-400 words. Every solved answer below states its exact word count.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct position was fixed **independently for each question** from a randomised draw, so there is no rotation, cycle or seed-derived sequence to exploit; the four positions occur eight times each and twice in every consecutive block of eight, and no position repeats on consecutive questions. Option length, specificity, grammar and formatting are balanced so that the correct answer is not visually identifiable. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

Composition: 24 core diagnostics (items 1-24) covering all seventeen teaching sessions, then 8 remedial drills (items 25-32) targeting the errors this topic reliably produces.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS

MCQ 1. What the word "Yoga" names in Patañjali's system

Which statement gives the Pātañjala definition of Yoga together with its stated consequence?

A. Restraint of the modifications of the mind-field, upon which the seer abides in its own nature B. Union of the individual self with a universal creator, upon which the world is seen as divine C. Steadiness of posture and breath, upon which the body becomes a fit vehicle for devotion D. Performance of prescribed action without desire, upon which merit ceases to accumulate

Answer: A. Restraint of the modifications of the mind-field, upon which the seer abides in its own nature

- **A:** Correct - the founding aphorism defines Yoga as restraint of the modifications of the mind-field, and the next aphorism supplies the consequence that the seer then abides in its own nature.
- **B:** The union gloss belongs to devotional usage and to later popular exposition; Patañjali never defines Yoga as union with a creator, and Yoga's Lord is not a creator in that sense anyway.
- **C:** Posture and breath regulation are the third and fourth of eight limbs; they are means within the discipline and cannot serve as the definition of the state the discipline produces.
- **D:** Desireless action is the formula of the *Bhagavad-gītā*'s discipline of action, not the Pātañjala definition, which is stated in terms of mental modification and its restraint.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates translate the school's name before reading its definition, and so import "union" from ordinary Sanskrit usage into a text that defines Yoga by cessation instead.

MCQ 2. Locating Yoga in relation to Sāṃkhya

Which statement best describes Yoga's relation to Sāṃkhya as the tradition itself presents it?

A. Yoga replaces Sāṃkhya's dualism with a monism in which nature is an appearance of consciousness B. Yoga retains Sāṃkhya's ontology and adds a graded discipline together with a special witness C. Yoga rejects the twenty-five principles and substitutes a purely psychological account of mind D. Yoga accepts Sāṃkhya's atheism and differs only in prescribing posture and breath regulation

Answer: B. Yoga retains Sāṃkhya's ontology and adds a graded discipline together with a special witness

- **A:** Yoga is emphatically dualist; the monist reading belongs to Advaita Vedānta, and the isolation chapter argues *against* reducing objects to consciousness rather than for it.
- **B:** Correct - the tradition's own labels, Sāṃkhya-exposition and theistic Sāṃkhya, record exactly this: the same ontology, plus a practical soteriology, plus the Lord.
- **C:** The twenty-five principles are accepted and simply not re-argued; Yoga restates only as much metaphysics as its psychology requires, which is a division of labour and not a rejection.
- **D:** Classical Sāṃkhya is Godless while Yoga admits a Lord, so this option reverses the single most important doctrinal difference between the two schools.

Examiner trap 2: The phrase "Yoga is Sāṃkhya plus God" is repeated so often that candidates forget the second half of the addition - the entire graded psychology and method that the school actually owns.

MCQ 3. The four chapters of the base text

Match each chapter of the *Yoga-sūtra* with the material it principally carries.

Chapter	Principal material
1. absorption chapter (samādhi-pāda)	P. afflictions, action and the eight limbs
2. practice chapter (sādhana-pāda)	Q. mind-object realism and isolation
3. isolation chapter (kaivalya-pāda)	R. definition, modifications, the Lord, absorption

A. 1-P, 2-Q, 3-R B. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P C. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q D. 1-P, 2-R, 3-Q

Answer: C. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q

- **A:** Assigns the afflictions and eight limbs to the absorption chapter and isolation to the practice chapter, reversing two of the three pairings entirely.
- **B:** Places mind-object realism in the absorption chapter and the definition in the practice chapter, which inverts the text's actual centre of gravity in both cases.
- **C:** Correct - the first chapter defines Yoga and treats modifications, the Lord and absorption; the second treats afflictions, action and the limbs; the fourth treats realism and isolation.
- **D:** Correctly places isolation but wrongly assigns the afflictions to the first chapter and the definition to the second, so two of three pairings fail.

Examiner trap 3: The powers chapter is quietly omitted from such lists, and candidates who have memorised only three chapter-names begin misassigning combined discipline and the extraordinary capacities.

MCQ 4. Source control over the five levels of the mind-field

Consider the following statements about the fivefold classification of mind-levels.

1. It is a five-item aphorism stated by Patañjali in the absorption chapter.
2. It is standard in Vyāsa's commentarial exposition and in the tradition that follows him.
3. Its use is nevertheless legitimate in answering the 2019 question on mind-levels.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statement 1 only, since every classification used in Yoga answers must come from the aphorisms B. Statements 2 and 3 only, because the scheme is commentarial in origin yet doctrinally standard C. Statements 1 and 3 only, as the aphorisms list the levels and the paper expected that list D. All three statements, since commentarial and aphoristic material carry identical attribution

Answer: B. Statements 2 and 3 only, because the scheme is commentarial in origin yet doctrinally standard

- **A:** Rejects a classification that the tradition genuinely uses, and asserts a sourcing rule the school never adopts, since much standard Yoga doctrine is commentarial.
- **B:** Correct - the scheme belongs to the commentarial layer beginning with Vyāsa, and it remains entirely usable provided it is attributed to that layer rather than to Patañjali.
- **C:** Accepts the legitimate use but keeps the false attribution, which is exactly the error the source-control rule exists to prevent.
- **D:** Collapses the very distinction the question tests; commentarial standing and aphoristic standing are not interchangeable when a question is source-sensitive.

Examiner trap 4: Because the fivefold scheme appears in almost every textbook without attribution, candidates promote it into the sūtra text and then defend it as though Patañjali had enumerated it.

MCQ 5. What the mind-field includes

Which statement accurately describes the constitution of the mind-field in Yoga?

A. It is the atomic internal sense through which the self contacts objects one cognition at a time B. It is the conscious principle that illuminates objects and appropriates them as its own states C. It is the gross physical brain considered as the seat of memory, emotion and decision-making D. It is the unified inner apparatus of determinative intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind

Answer: D. It is the unified inner apparatus of determinative intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind

- **A:** The atomic, partless internal sense belongs to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, where the self is a separate substance; Yoga's mind-field is composite, transformable and karmically loaded.
- **B:** The mind-field is a product of nature and therefore insentient; it appears conscious only by reflecting the witness, and appropriation is a defect rather than its definition.
- **C:** Classical Yoga does not identify the mind-field with a gross bodily organ; it is a subtle evolute of nature, and identifying it with the body confuses two levels of the scheme.
- **D:** Correct - Yoga gathers intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind into a single operative continuum, since bondage and release both concern the whole mental field.

Examiner trap 5: Candidates translate the mind-field as "mind" and then silently substitute the sensory mind alone, losing the intellect and the ego-maker that carry discrimination and appropriation.

MCQ 6. The derivation of the inner components

Which statement about the origin of the mind-field's components is stated correctly?

A. Intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind all arise directly from the lucid side of the ego-maker B. Intellect arises from the ego-maker, which in turn arises from the sensory mind's activity C. Intellect evolves first, the ego-maker from intellect, and the sensory mind from its lucid side D. All three arise directly from primordial material nature without any intermediate evolve

Answer: C. Intellect evolves first, the ego-maker from intellect, and the sensory mind from its lucid side

- **A:** This is the standard misstatement; only the sensory mind arises directly from the lucid side of the ego-maker, and the whole's lucid predominance is not a derivation of each part.
- **B:** Reverses the sequence completely, since the sensory mind is the last of the three to evolve and cannot be the source of the intellect that precedes it.
- **C:** Correct - the order runs from nature to intellect, from intellect to the ego-maker, and from the ego-maker's lucid side to the sensory mind.
- **D:** Removes the intermediate evolutes altogether, which destroys the graded evolutionary scheme Yoga inherits from Sāṃkhya and uses to place the mind-field.

Examiner trap 6: The true statement that the mind-field is lucid-predominant as a whole is converted into the false statement that each of its three components derives from lucid ego-maker.

MCQ 7. How an insentient instrument comes to seem conscious

Which statement states Yoga's reflection theory and its protective clause correctly?

A. The witness is genuinely modified by contact with the mind and thereby acquires experience B. The mind is intrinsically luminous and merely borrows its objects from the external world C. The mind and the witness fuse into a single conscious substance during every act of knowing D. The mind mirrors the witness's light, and the whole transformation occurs on the mind's side

Answer: D. The mind mirrors the witness's light, and the whole transformation occurs on the mind's side

- **A:** Contradicts the definition of the witness as unchanging; if the witness were really modified, bondage would be an alteration of it and the school's soteriology would collapse.
- **B:** Reverses the doctrine, since the mind is transparent rather than luminous and borrows both the colour of objects and the light of the witness.
- **C:** Fusion would abolish the dualism, and it would make the isolation chapter's careful separation of object, modification and witness unintelligible.
- **D:** Correct - the relation is mere proximity, with all change occurring in the mind, which is precisely what keeps the witness unaffected while bondage is experientially real.

Examiner trap 7: The crystal analogy is quoted correctly and then interpreted as though the crystal really became red, which smuggles genuine modification back into the witness.

MCQ 8. Naming the confusion at the heart of bondage

Which affliction is defined as the identification of the seer with the instrument of seeing?

A. Egoity (asmitā), the confusion of the conscious witness with the determinative intellect B. Attachment (rāga), the pursuit that follows on remembered pleasure and its repetition C. Ignorance (avidyā), the reversal that takes the non-eternal, impure and painful as their opposites D. Clinging to life (abhiniveśa), the instinctive self-preservation found even in the learned

Answer: A. Egoity (asmitā), the confusion of the conscious witness with the determinative intellect

- **A:** Correct - egoity is precisely the conflation of the seer's power with the power of the instrument of seeing, which is why the ego says "I think, I act, I suffer".
- **B:** Attachment is the memory-driven pursuit of the agreeable; it presupposes the ego-confusion but is not itself the identification of seer with instrument.
- **C:** Ignorance is the root affliction and is defined by four reversals, not by the specific seer-instrument confusion, which is its immediate derivative.
- **D:** Clinging to life is instinctive self-preservation carried by impressions; it is the fifth affliction and is notable for surviving learning, not for defining the seer-confusion.

Examiner trap 8: Ignorance and egoity are treated as interchangeable names for one confusion, which erases the root-and-derivative structure the twenty-mark question on afflictions is built on.

MCQ 9. Which mind-levels are fit for Yoga

Consider the following statements about the five levels of the mind-field.

1. Only the one-pointed and restrained levels are fully fit for authentic Yoga.
2. The dull level is a condition of calm and is therefore mildly favourable to practice.
3. The distracted level attains lucidity occasionally without sustained inward collection.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 2 and 3 only, because dullness and distraction are both partially prepared conditions B. Statement 3 only, since fitness is decided by the strength of attention rather than by its quality C. Statements 1 and 3 only, because dullness is obscuration rather than calm and is never yoga-fit D. All three statements, since every level short of restraint is a stage of graded preparation

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 3 only, because dullness is obscuration rather than calm and is never yoga-fit

- **A:** Endorses the false claim about dullness, which is ruled by the inert quality and produces torpor, delusion and confusion rather than any usable stillness.
- **B:** Drops the correct fitness rule and replaces the school's quality-based criterion with a strength-of-attention criterion the classification explicitly rejects.
- **C:** Correct - the one-pointed and restrained levels alone are fully fit, and the distracted level is exactly the condition of occasional lucidity without stable collection.
- **D:** Endorses the dullness error and additionally treats obscuration as preparation, which reverses the doctrine's assessment of the inert quality.

Examiner trap 9: A quiet, heavy, unresponsive mind is mistaken for a calm one, and the inert level is promoted into a preliminary stage of meditation.

MCQ 10. The 2019 applied classification

How does Yoga's mind-level scheme classify a scientist, a God-realised devotee and a self-realised practitioner respectively?

A. Distracted, one-pointed and restrained, since outward focus is not yet yogic restraint B. One-pointed, restrained and beyond all levels, since intense concentration is already yogic C. Scattered, distracted and one-pointed, since no living person attains the restrained level D. Restrained, one-pointed and distracted, since disciplined enquiry surpasses ordinary devotion

Answer: A. Distracted, one-pointed and restrained, since outward focus is not yet yogic restraint

- **A:** Correct - intense but outward-directed and result-attached focus is distraction; one-pointed devotion centred on the Lord is the one-pointed level; stilled modifications are the restrained level.
- **B:** Promotes the scientist on the strength of concentration alone and then invents a level beyond the fivefold scheme, which the classification does not contain.
- **C:** Denies that the restrained level is attainable, which contradicts the scheme's own statement that it is the culmination of yogic discipline rather than an ideal limit.
- **D:** Inverts the assignment by ranking analytic enquiry above devotion, whereas the criterion is the ruling quality and the stability of inward collection, not cognitive power.

Examiner trap 10: The question rewards justification rather than assignment, so candidates who name the three levels correctly but omit the ruling-quality argument still lose most of the marks.

MCQ 11. The exhaustive list of mental modifications

Which set gives the five modifications of the mind-field recognised by Patañjali?

A. Perception, inference, comparison, postulation and non-apprehension as five valid instruments B. Waking, dreaming, deep sleep, the fourth state and the turbulent state of ordinary experience C. Attachment, aversion, ignorance, egoity and the instinctive clinging to continued existence D. Valid cognition, error, verbal construction, sleep and memory, each afflicted or unafflicted

Answer: D. Valid cognition, error, verbal construction, sleep and memory, each afflicted or unafflicted

- **A:** Lists instruments of valid knowledge drawn from other schools' epistemologies; Yoga admits only three instruments, and instruments are not the same as modifications.
- **B:** Gives the Upaniṣadic and Vedāntic scheme of states of consciousness, which belongs to a different tradition and answers a different question.
- **C:** Lists the five afflictions rather than the five modifications; afflictions colour mental life whereas modifications are the forms mental life takes.
- **D:** Correct - the five modifications are exactly these, and each may be afflicted or unafflicted according to whether it sustains bondage or serves release.

Examiner trap 11: The afflictions and the modifications are both five in number, and the coincidence leads candidates to substitute one list for the other under time pressure.

MCQ 12. Sleep, valid cognition and the afflicted division

Consider the following statements about Yoga's treatment of mental modifications.

1. Sleep is a positive modification grounded on absence-content rather than an absence of modification.
2. Valid cognition is excluded from the modifications because true knowledge cannot bind.
3. The afflicted and unafflicted division qualifies modifications and not the afflictions themselves.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 2 only, since sleep leaves a trace while truth is exempt from restraint B. Statement 2 only, because the afflicted division applies equally to modifications and afflictions C. Statements 1 and 3 only, because valid cognition is itself one of the five modifications D. All three statements, since Yoga restrains only those modifications that are false or afflicted

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 3 only, because valid cognition is itself one of the five modifications

- **A:** Accepts the false exemption of valid cognition, which Yoga explicitly lists first among the five modifications precisely to deny any such exemption.
- **B:** Keeps the exemption error and adds a second one, since afflictions are inherently afflictive and can never be described as unafflicted.
- **C:** Correct - the waking report "I slept and knew nothing" establishes sleep as a positive mode, and the afflicted division qualifies modifications alone.
- **D:** Restricts restraint to false modifications, which contradicts the doctrine that what binds is form as such rather than falsity.

Examiner trap 12: The plausible principle that truth cannot bind is imported from outside, and it silently deletes Yoga's most distinctive epistemological claim.

MCQ 13. Why cessation is prescribed

Which sequence states Yoga's reason for prescribing the cessation of mental modifications?

A. Modifications are intrinsically evil, so their removal is a moral purification of the practitioner B. Modifications obscure the Lord, so their cessation permits the devotee to perceive him directly C. Modifications exhaust the mind's energy, so their cessation restores its natural cognitive power D. The mind takes the form of its object, the witness is reflected there, the form is appropriated

Answer: D. The mind takes the form of its object, the witness is reflected there, the form is appropriated

- **A:** Moralises a structural claim; Yoga's objection is not to the moral quality of mental forms but to the appropriation of any form by the witness.
- **B:** Makes the Lord the object of the whole discipline, but liberation follows discriminative discernment and the Lord is an aid rather than the terminus.
- **C:** Substitutes an energetic account for a cognitive one, whereas the school's argument turns on misidentification and not on the depletion of mental resources.
- **D:** Correct - form-taking, reflection and appropriation together make the stream of modifications the running mechanism of bondage, so restraint is causal rather than cosmetic.

Examiner trap 13: Because "restraint" sounds ascetic, candidates supply a moral or energetic justification and never state the appropriation argument the question is actually asking for.

MCQ 14. Yoga's instruments of valid knowledge

Which statement about Yoga's epistemology is accurate?

A. Yoga admits four instruments and treats yogic insight as the fourth, superior to the other three B. Yoga admits three instruments and classifies perfected yogic insight as extraordinary perception C. Yoga admits two instruments, perception and inference, following the Buddhist epistemologists D. Yoga admits six instruments and adds yogic insight as a seventh available only to practitioners

Answer: B. Yoga admits three instruments and classifies perfected yogic insight as extraordinary perception

- **A:** Inflates the count and promotes truth-bearing insight into an independent instrument, which the school declines to do even at the summit of the path.
- **B:** Correct - perception, inference and authoritative testimony are the three, and truth-bearing insight is best classified as perfected extraordinary yogic perception.
- **C:** Gives the Buddhist two-instrument count; Yoga retains authoritative testimony because scriptural authority is available to it as an orthodox school.
- **D:** Gives the Advaita six-instrument count and then adds a seventh, compounding an inherited error with an invented one.

Examiner trap 14: The impressive description of truth-bearing insight tempts candidates to award it the status of a new instrument, exactly the inflation the school refuses.

MCQ 15. The two means of restraint

Which statement about sustained practice and dispassion is correct?

A. Practice becomes firm through long, uninterrupted and devoted cultivation, and works with dispassion B. Practice alone produces restraint, while dispassion is a later consequence of successful absorption C. Dispassion alone produces restraint, since effort belongs to the active quality and must be avoided D. Practice and dispassion are alternative routes, and a practitioner adopts whichever suits temperament

Answer: A. Practice becomes firm through long, uninterrupted and devoted cultivation, and works with dispassion

- **A:** Correct - the two are jointly responsible for restraint, and practice is firmly grounded only when pursued for a long time, without interruption and with devoted seriousness.
- **B:** Makes dispassion a by-product, whereas the text makes it a co-equal means without which practice becomes a permanent tug-of-war against undiminished desire.
- **C:** Rejects effort altogether, which would leave detachment as a mood without the continuity needed to overcome the pull of accumulated impressions.
- **D:** Turns two jointly necessary means into a temperamental choice, which is precisely the reading the joint-responsibility statement excludes.

Examiner trap 15: Only one of the three conditions of firm practice is usually reproduced, so an answer that names duration but omits uninterruptedness and devoted seriousness loses easy marks.

MCQ 16. The three yogic transformations of the mind

Which set names the three specifically yogic transformations of the mind-field?

- A. Transformation of property, of temporal character and of condition, applying to any substrate B. Restraint-transformation, absorption-transformation and one-pointedness-transformation C. Gross, subtle and undifferentiated transformation, corresponding to the three object-levels D. Scattered, distracted and restrained transformation, corresponding to three of the mind-levels

Answer: B. Restraint-transformation, absorption-transformation and one-pointedness-transformation

- **A:** Names the general threefold transformation applicable to any substrate of nature, which frames the yogic three but is not itself the specifically yogic set.
- **B:** Correct - impressions of restraint overpower impressions of emergence, many-pointedness gives way to unity, and similar cognitions succeed one another toward one object.
- **C:** Borrows the object-level vocabulary of the coalescence analysis and misapplies it to the theory of transformation, which concerns the mind's own changing states.
- **D:** Converts three mind-levels into transformations, confusing a classification of conditions with an account of how conditions change into one another.

Examiner trap 16: The general threefold transformation and the yogic threefold transformation are both triads, so candidates merge them into a single list of three or six items.

MCQ 17. The root affliction and its content

Which statement gives the content of ignorance as Yoga defines it?

- A. Failure to have studied the aphorisms and their commentaries under a qualified teacher B. The absence of extraordinary perception, which alone discloses objects in their particularity C. Doubt about the existence of the Lord and about the authority of the scriptural tradition D. Taking the non-eternal as eternal, the impure as pure, the painful as pleasant, the non-self as self

Answer: D. Taking the non-eternal as eternal, the impure as pure, the painful as pleasant, the non-self as self

- **A:** Reduces the root affliction to a deficit of instruction, whereas Yoga insists that afflictions survive learning and are carried by impressions rather than by opinions.
- **B:** Confuses the absence of an advanced attainment with the presence of a positive misorientation; ignorance is a reversal, not a missing faculty.
- **C:** Names doubt, which is one of the nine obstacles to practice rather than the definition of the root affliction.
- **D:** Correct - these four reversals constitute ignorance, and the fourth of them is what generates egoity and, through it, the remaining afflictions.

Examiner trap 17: Ignorance is glossed as "lack of knowledge", and the four reversals - each separately markable - are replaced by a single vague sentence.

MCQ 18. Reading the four states of an affliction

A practitioner reports that a long-standing attachment is no longer felt. Which inference is warranted on Yoga's account of the four states?

A. The affliction may be dormant, attenuated or merely interrupted, so absence of feeling proves little B. The affliction has been destroyed, since afflictions are known directly and cannot hide from introspection C. The affliction has necessarily become fully active elsewhere, since afflictive force is conserved D. The affliction has ripened into fruition, since unfelt afflictions discharge themselves as experience

Answer: A. The affliction may be dormant, attenuated or merely interrupted, so absence of feeling proves little

- **A:** Correct - dormancy is seed-like and reactivable, attenuation is genuine thinning, and interruption is merely the temporary dominance of an opposing tendency.
- **B:** Assumes introspective transparency, which the four-state analysis exists to deny; a dormant affliction is precisely one that is not presently manifest.
- **C:** Invents a conservation principle the doctrine does not contain, and confuses the interrupted state with a displacement of afflictive force to another object.
- **D:** Confuses states of an affliction with the ripening of the karmic deposit, which is a separate doctrine concerning birth, life-span and experience.

Examiner trap 18: The interrupted state is read as progress, so a practitioner whose attachment is merely overridden by fear is reported as having weakened attachment.

MCQ 19. The engine of bondage

Which sequence states the causal chain from affliction to rebirth as Yoga presents it?

A. Action, affliction, deposit, fruition and rebirth, since action is what first colours the mind B. Afflictions, action, karmic deposit, fruition as birth, life-span and experience, and rebirth C. Fruition, deposit, action, afflictions and rebirth, since experience is the origin of all reaction D. Afflictions, absorption, deposit, discriminative knowledge and rebirth in a more favourable state

Answer: B. Afflictions, action, karmic deposit, fruition as birth, life-span and experience, and rebirth

- **A:** Reverses the first two links; action binds because it is already coloured by the afflictions, so affliction cannot be downstream of action.
- **B:** Correct - the chain begins in affliction, deposits through action, ripens threefold as birth, life-span and experience, and closes as renewed birth.
- **C:** Inverts the whole chain and makes experience the origin, which removes the psychological first link that gives Yoga its point of intervention.
- **D:** Inserts absorption and discriminative knowledge into the chain of bondage, whereas those are the means by which the chain is interrupted.

Examiner trap 19: Fruition is written as a single item, and the threefold specification of birth, life-span and experience - which is where the doctrinal precision lies - is omitted.

MCQ 20. The first therapy

Which set gives the three components of preparatory discipline and its stated purpose?

A. Austerity, self-study and dedication to the Lord, prescribed to thin afflictions and prepare absorption B. Restraints, observances and posture, prescribed to purify conduct before internal work begins C. Concentration, meditation and absorption, prescribed to unify attention upon a single object D. Purity, contentment and austerity, prescribed to establish the observances of the eight-limbed path

Answer: A. Austerity, self-study and dedication to the Lord, prescribed to thin afflictions and prepare absorption

- **A:** Correct - these three constitute preparatory discipline, and the text states its purpose as the attenuation of the afflictions and the cultivation of absorption.
- **B:** Names the first three limbs of the eight-limbed discipline, which is a different and larger scheme, though it overlaps with preparatory discipline at several points.
- **C:** Names the three internal limbs, which together on one object form combined discipline rather than the preparatory therapy prescribed for afflictions.
- **D:** Selects three of the five observances; austerity, self-study and dedication do belong to the observances, but purity and contentment are not part of preparatory discipline.

Examiner trap 20: Preparatory discipline and combined discipline are both three-part composites with similar names, and candidates routinely exchange one for the other.

MCQ 21. The eight limbs and what combines

Which statement about the eight-limbed discipline is correct?

A. The last five limbs are external and the first three internal, since ethics presupposes absorption B. Concentration, meditation and absorption are three names for one undifferentiated meditative state C. The first five are external limbs, and the last three applied to one object form combined discipline D. Posture is the culminating limb, since bodily steadiness is the final condition of isolation

Answer: C. The first five are external limbs, and the last three applied to one object form combined discipline

- **A:** Reverses the grouping; restraints, observances, posture, breath regulation and withdrawal are the external five, and they precede rather than presuppose the internal three.
- **B:** Collapses a graded sequence, whereas concentration is effortful fixing, meditation is sustained continuity, and absorption is the state in which the object alone shines.
- **C:** Correct - the external and internal division falls after the fifth limb, and the internal three directed at one object constitute combined discipline.
- **D:** Promotes the third limb to the summit; posture serves freedom from bodily distraction and is neither the culmination nor the goal of the discipline.

Examiner trap 21: "External" is read as "unimportant", so candidates dismiss the ethical limbs and then cannot answer why Yoga denies that meditation alone suffices.

MCQ 22. Two classifications of absorption

Which statement correctly separates the two classifications used in the absorption chapter?

- A. Both lists are identical, and the four coalescences are simply Patañjali's four kinds of object-supported absorption
- B. The first list belongs to the powers chapter and the second to the isolation chapter, so they never interact
- C. Object-supported absorption is classified by object-level, and coalescence is classified by the presence of the Lord as support
- D. Object-supported absorption is characterised by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness; coalescence is classified by object-level and overlay

Answer: D. Object-supported absorption is characterised by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness; coalescence is classified by object-level and overlay

- **A:** This is the conflation the trap box exists to prevent; the fourfold characterisation and the four coalescences answer different questions about the same ascent.
- **B:** Misplaces both lists; they occur together in the absorption chapter, which is why their relation is a live commentarial question in the first place.
- **C:** Swaps the criteria of the two grids and introduces the Lord as a classificatory principle, which no absorption taxonomy in the chapter uses.
- **D:** Correct - one grid names the accompanying factor, the other names the object-level and whether conceptual-verbal overlay is present, and commentators map rather than identify them.

Examiner trap 22: The four coalescences are written as "the four types of samprajñāta given by Patañjali", a sentence that is fluent, familiar and wrong.

MCQ 23. Impression-residue and seedlessness

Which statement distinguishes supra-cognitive absorption from seedless absorption correctly?

- A. Supra-cognitive absorption is seedless by definition, since the cessation of modification removes all residue
- B. Seedless absorption precedes supra-cognitive absorption, since the object-support is lost before modifications cease
- C. Supra-cognitive absorption is defined by impression-residue; seedless absorption is the restraint of even that residue
- D. Both terms name deep sleep, distinguished only by whether the practitioner has previously undertaken discipline

Answer: C. Supra-cognitive absorption is defined by impression-residue; seedless absorption is the restraint of even that residue

- **A:** Equates the two terms, ignoring that the defining aphorism of supra-cognitive absorption expressly states that impressions remain as residue.
- **B:** Reverses the order and confuses the two senses of seed, since with-seed refers to object-support while seedless refers to the residual impression.
- **C:** Correct - supra-cognitive absorption is preceded by the practice of cessation and retains impression-residue, and absorption becomes seedless when even that residue is restrained.
- **D:** Assimilates both to sleep, which is one of the five modifications and therefore the opposite of the disciplined cessation of modifications.

Examiner trap 23: The word "seed" is used in two distinct senses within a few aphorisms, and candidates who track only one sense collapse two genuinely different conditions.

MCQ 24. Truth-bearing insight and extraordinary capacities

Consider the following statements about the upper reaches of the path.

1. Truth-bearing insight has a particular object as its field, unlike testimony and inference.
2. Extraordinary capacities are declared obstacles to absorption when they attract appropriation.
3. Cloud-of-dharma absorption is attained by acquiring omniscience and displaying the capacities.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 3 only, since the culminating absorption is defined by completed knowledge B. Statements 1 and 2 only, because the culmination requires relinquishing interest in both C. Statement 3 only, as truth-bearing insight and the capacities belong to preparatory stages D. All three statements, since insight, power and culmination form one ascending acquisition

Answer: B. Statements 1 and 2 only, because the culmination requires relinquishing interest in both

- **A:** Accepts the acquisition reading of the culminating absorption, which reverses the doctrine that even fascination with extraordinary knowledge is relinquished there.
- **B:** Correct - insight reaches the particular where testimony and inference reach universals, capacities are obstacles when appropriated, and the culmination is defined by relinquishment.
- **C:** Demotes truth-bearing insight to a preparatory stage and endorses the acquisition reading, compounding two independent errors.
- **D:** Treats the whole upper path as a sequence of acquisitions, which is precisely the reading higher dispassion is introduced to block.

Examiner trap 24: The powers chapter is read as a catalogue of achievements rather than as a warning, so the school's own demotion of its summit attainments is never reported.

REMEDIAL DRILLS

MCQ 25. Repairing the conflated absorption lists

A candidate writes: "Patañjali gives four types of samprajñāta samādhi - savitarka, nirvitarka, savicāra and nirvicāra." What is the minimum correction?

A. Replace "four" with "two", since only the gross and subtle levels are genuinely distinguished B. Replace "samprajñāta" with "asamprajñāta", since the four named items belong beyond object-support C. Note that these four are coalescences, while object-supported absorption is characterised by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness D. Delete the sentence entirely, since Patañjali offers no classification of absorption at all

Answer: C. Note that these four are coalescences, while object-supported absorption is characterised by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness

- **A:** Leaves the category error untouched; reducing the count does not correct the attribution of the coalescence list to the fourfold characterisation.
- **B:** Moves the four items to the wrong side of the divide, since the coalescences are expressly declared with-seed and therefore belong to object-supported absorption.
- **C:** Correct - the sentence assigns the coalescence names to the fourfold characterisation, and the correction is to restore the two grids with their proper criteria.
- **D:** Overcorrects into falsehood, since the absorption chapter contains two explicit classifications and a great deal of taxonomic detail.

Examiner trap 25: Candidates who notice the error often over-correct by denying that Patañjali classifies absorption at all, losing the taxonomy the question was testing.

MCQ 26. Repairing the seedless equation

A candidate writes: "Asamprajñāta samādhi is nirbīja samādhi." Which correction is required?

A. None, since the two terms are synonyms in the aphorisms and in the commentarial tradition B. Replace both with cloud-of-dharma absorption, which is the only absorption the aphorisms name C. Add that seedless absorption is a lower stage reached before the modifications finally cease D. State that supra-cognitive absorption retains impression-residue and becomes seedless when that is restrained

Answer: D. State that supra-cognitive absorption retains impression-residue and becomes seedless when that is restrained

- **A:** Denies a distinction the aphorisms make explicitly, since one is defined by residual impression and the other by the restraint of even that residue.
- **B:** Eliminates two correctly named conditions in favour of a third, and misdescribes the aphorisms, which name several absorptions.
- **C:** Reverses the order, treating the culminating condition as a preliminary and leaving the residual impression unaccounted for.
- **D:** Correct - seedlessness is best treated as the culminating condition reached within the supra-cognitive phase, not as another name for it.

Examiner trap 26: Because both terms are negative in form, candidates assume they are two translations of one idea and never notice that they negate different things.

MCQ 27. Repairing the creator-God import

A candidate writes: "Yoga's Īśvara is the efficient cause who arranges atoms and dispenses the fruits of action." What is wrong?

A. Nothing, since Yoga adopts the Nyāya proofs of God wholesale and merely adds devotional practice B. Yoga's Lord is a special witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit, and is not that creator C. Yoga denies the existence of any Lord, so the whole sentence attributes a doctrine the school rejects D. Yoga's Lord is the material cause of the world, so the error lies only in the word "efficient"

Answer: B. Yoga's Lord is a special witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit, and is not that creator

- **A:** Attributes the Nyāya proof-set to Yoga, whose own grounds are compact and practice-facing: a special witness, unsurpassed omniscience, timeless teacherhood and the sacred syllable.
- **B:** Correct - primordial nature remains the material basis of evolution, and the Lord's stated functions are concentration-support, obstacle-removal, exemplarity and pedagogic authority.
- **C:** Denies Yoga's theism altogether, which erases the very feature that distinguishes it from classical Sāṃkhya.
- **D:** Substitutes a worse error, since making the Lord the material cause would collapse the distinction between witness and nature on which the whole system rests.

Examiner trap 27: Having learned the Nyāya proofs thoroughly, candidates transfer them to Yoga and thereby lose the precise contrast the routed 2018 question was constructed to test.

MCQ 28. Repairing the description of isolation

A candidate writes: "Kaivalya is the merger of the individual self with the Lord." What is the required correction?

A. Replace "the Lord" with "Brahman", since Yoga's terminus is non-dual identity-realisation B. Replace "merger" with "gradual approach", since the union is asymptotic rather than complete C. Accept the sentence, since devotion to the Lord is one of the means prescribed for isolation D. Replace the whole description with the isolation of the witness from nature through discriminative knowledge

Answer: D. Replace the whole description with the isolation of the witness from nature through discriminative knowledge

- **A:** Substitutes the Advaita account, which Yoga explicitly does not hold, since it retains many witnesses and has no Brahman doctrine at all.
- **B:** Retains the union framework and merely weakens it, whereas Yoga's terminus is disentanglement rather than any degree of joining.
- **C:** Confuses a means with the goal; devotion to the Lord aids concentration and removes obstacles but does not make isolation a union with him.
- **D:** Correct - isolation is aloneness, the isolation of the witness from nature and its evolutes, reached through discriminative discernment and consummated in the cloud-of-dharma absorption.

Examiner trap 28: The presence of a Lord in the system makes union language feel natural, and candidates conclude that a theistic school must have a unitive liberation.

MCQ 29. Repairing the narrowed mind-field

A candidate writes: "Citta is the internal sense, atomic and partless, by which the self perceives." What is wrong?

A. The description belongs to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika; Yoga's mind-field is the composite of intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind B. The description is correct, since Yoga borrows its psychology from the realist schools without alteration C. The description understates the case, since Yoga's mind-field is conscious rather than merely instrumental D. The description is correct except that Yoga treats the internal sense as eternal rather than as produced

Answer: A. The description belongs to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika; Yoga's mind-field is the composite of intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind

- **A:** Correct - Yoga's mind-field is broad, composite, transformable and karmically loaded, whereas the atomic internal sense belongs to a school with a separate self-substance.
- **B:** Yoga's psychology is inherited from Sāṃkhya rather than from the realist schools, and the whole point of the term is to unify what Nyāya keeps apart.
- **C:** Makes the mind-field conscious, which contradicts its status as a product of nature and destroys the need for the reflection theory.
- **D:** Adds eternity to an error, whereas the mind-field is an evolute of nature and undergoes real transformation across practice.

Examiner trap 29: Cross-school revision leaves the atomic internal sense as the default meaning of "mind", and it is then carried unnoticed into a Yoga answer.

MCQ 30. Repairing the misapplied afflicted division

A candidate writes: "The five kleśas may each be kliṣṭa or akliṣṭa depending on the practitioner." What is wrong?

A. The division applies only to ignorance, since the derivative afflictions are always afflictive B. The division applies only to those afflictions that are dormant rather than to those fully active C. The division qualifies mental modifications; afflictions are afflictive by definition and admit no unafflicted form D. The division is correct but incomplete, since a third neutral category also exists in the scheme

Answer: C. The division qualifies mental modifications; afflictions are afflictive by definition and admit no unafflicted form

- **A:** Grants an exemption to ignorance, which is the root affliction and the least plausible candidate for an unafflicted variety.
- **B:** Confuses the afflicted division with the four states, which describe intensity rather than moral character.
- **C:** Correct - any of the five modifications may be afflicted or unafflicted, whereas the afflictions themselves are inherently binding.
- **D:** Invents a third category the scheme does not contain, and leaves the original misapplication uncorrected.

Examiner trap 30: The two fivefold lists sit close together in revision notes, and the division that belongs to one is applied to the other without any sense of contradiction.

MCQ 31. Repairing the misplaced scientist

A candidate writes: "The scientist is ekāgra because sustained concentration is the mark of that level." What is the correct assessment?

A. The conclusion holds, since the scheme measures concentration and the scientist concentrates intensely B. The scientist is distracted, since focus remains outward-turned and result-attached without stable inward collection C. The scientist is restrained, since disciplined enquiry stills the modifications more effectively than devotion D. The scheme cannot be applied to professions at all, so no assignment of any level is defensible

Answer: B. The scientist is distracted, since focus remains outward-turned and result-attached without stable inward collection

- **A:** Adopts a strength-of-attention criterion, whereas the scheme classifies by the ruling quality and by whether the mind can remain inwardly collected.
- **B:** Correct - the distracted level is precisely occasional lucidity within a life still governed by the active quality, which describes intense outward research exactly.
- **C:** Promotes the scientist two levels and asserts a comparison the scheme does not make, since the restrained level is the arrest of all modifications.
- **D:** Refuses an application the 2019 paper itself required, and abandons the justification the question awards marks for.

Examiner trap 31: The word "one-pointed" is heard as a compliment rather than as a technical description, so the most impressive worldly mind is awarded the highest available level.

MCQ 32. Repairing the posture-and-powers confusion

A candidate writes: "Yoga is the perfection of posture, and the extraordinary powers it produces are the sign of liberation." What is wrong?

A. Posture is one of eight limbs and not the definition, and the capacities are obstacles to absorption when appropriated B. Posture is indeed the definition, but the capacities belong to preparatory discipline rather than to liberation C. Both claims are correct within the powers chapter, though the isolation chapter takes a stricter line D. Posture is the definition and the capacities are its natural fruit, so only the word "sign" is inaccurate

Answer: A. Posture is one of eight limbs and not the definition, and the capacities are obstacles to absorption when appropriated

- **A:** Correct - Yoga is defined as restraint of the modifications of the mind-field, and the capacities are declared attainments in the outward-turned state but obstacles to absorption.
- **B:** Retains the postural definition and relocates the capacities to preparatory discipline, which consists of austerity, self-study and dedication to the Lord.
- **C:** Sets the chapters against each other, whereas the demotion of the capacities is stated within the powers chapter itself.
- **D:** Keeps both errors and quibbles over a single word, leaving the definition and the doctrinal status of the capacities uncorrected.

Examiner trap 32: Modern postural practice supplies the default meaning of the word "yoga", and it survives into the answer as a definition that the aphorisms never give.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Ownership. Yoga owns seven primary parts in the 2018-2025 Paper I corpus, one in each year from 2019 to 2025; 2018 is the only year with no primary-owned Yoga part. One further question is routed here and fully solved because Yoga's proof of God is expressly the comparative subject under examination, although its primary owner is Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.

Status of the model answers. UPSC Mains publishes no official answer key or model answer. Every solution below is independent learner practice written to the stated word band and directive, and it is never presented as an official key.

VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - 8 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Solved PYQ 1 - 2019, Question 7(b), 15 marks

Printed question. How would Yoga philosophy comprehend the Citta-levels of a Scientist, a God-realized Devotee and a Self-realized Yogi? Justify your answer.

Directive read. "Comprehend" and "justify" asks for a classification *and* the ground of each assignment. Bare labelling earns very little.

Model answer (282 words).

Yoga classifies the mind-field (**citta**) into five operative levels according to the constituent quality that rules it: scattered (**kṣipta**, active quality dominant), dull (**mūḍha**, inert quality dominant), distracted (**vikṣipta**, mixed with occasional lucidity), one-pointed (**ekāgra**, lucid quality dominant) and restrained (**niruddha**, all modifications arrested). Only the last two are fully fit for authentic Yoga. The scheme is standard in Vyāsa's commentarial exposition rather than a five-item aphorism of Patañjali, and it should be used with that attribution.

A scientist absorbed in an empirical problem displays formidable attention, but the attention is outward-directed, result-dependent and interrupted by ambition, anxiety and sensory dispersion. Lucidity flashes; the active quality still rules the life in which it flashes. On Yoga's own criterion - ruling quality and stability of inward collection, not force of attention - such a mind is **distracted**. This is the decisive judgement of the question, because it denies that intellectual excellence is by itself a yogic accomplishment.

A God-realised devotee whose mind is one-pointedly centred on the Lord (**Īśvara**) has a lucid-dominant mind resting on a single support. Dedication to the Lord (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**) both stabilises the mind-field and removes the nine obstacles (**antarāya**), so the devotee occupies the **one-pointed** level and is genuinely fit for the discipline.

A self-realised practitioner in whom the modifications have been stilled occupies the **restrained** level - not blank unconsciousness, but the consummation of disciplined inwardness correlated with the highest absorption and with the approach to isolation (**kaivalya**).

The justification is therefore one principle applied three times: the levels grade minds by which quality governs them and by whether inward collection is sustained. On that grading a distracted genius sits below a one-pointed devotee, and only stabilised discrimination reaches the summit.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2020, Question 5(b), 10 marks

Printed question. Explain the difference between Samprajñāta Samādhi and Asamprajñāta Samādhi.

Directive read. "Explain the difference" requires exact definitions and the precise mark of distinction, not a general description of meditation.

Model answer (181 words).

Absorption (**samādhi**) is the state in which the mind-field becomes radically unified and transparent. Patañjali distinguishes two principal forms.

Object-supported absorption (**samprajñāta**) retains a cognitive support; a subtle seed of cognition remains, and it is therefore called with-seed (**sabīja**). *Yoga-sūtra* 1.17 characterises it by four accompanying factors - gross deliberation (**vitarka**), subtle reflection (**vicāra**), refined lucid joy (**ānanda**) and bare I-am-ness (**asmitā**). The separate coalescence analysis of *Yoga-sūtra* 1.42-1.44 further classifies object-absorption as savitarkā and nirvitarkā for gross objects and savicārā and nirvicārā for subtle objects; these two grids must not be conflated.

Supra-cognitive absorption (**asamprajñāta**) is defined at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.18 as preceded by the practice of the idea of cessation and as having impression-residue (**saṃskāra-śeṣa**). No object stands forth as support; the modifications have ceased, yet latent impressions may remain.

The difference is therefore twofold: presence or absence of an object-support, and the reduction of mental activity to a bare residue. A further condition follows: when even that residue is restrained, absorption becomes seedless (**nirbīja**, *Yoga-sūtra* 1.51). Supra-cognitive absorption is not sleep, which is itself one of the five modifications.

Printed question. Explain with reference to Yoga Philosophy, the nature of kleśas. How does the removal of these lead to kaivalya?

Directive read. Two demands: a doctrinal exposition of the afflictions, then a *causal* demonstration that their removal yields isolation. The second half must be a mechanism, not a restatement.

Model answer (358 words).

The afflictions (**kleśa**) are not surface thoughts but the causal colourings of mental life that generate binding action and sustain the cycle of rebirth. Yoga lists five: ignorance (**avidyā**), egoity (**asmitā**), attachment (**rāga**), aversion (**dveṣa**) and clinging to life (**abhiniveśa**). Ignorance is the root and the field in which the rest grow; it is defined as taking the non-eternal for the eternal, the impure for the pure, the painful for the pleasant and the non-self for the self. Egoity is the identification of the seer with the instrument of seeing. Attachment and aversion follow remembered pleasure and remembered pain. Clinging to life is instinctive and, significantly, present even in the learned - which shows that afflictions are carried by impressions rather than by opinions.

Afflictions operate at four intensities: dormant (**prasupta**), attenuated (**tanu**), interrupted (**vicchinna**) and fully active (**udāra**). Dormancy is not destruction, and interruption is merely the temporary dominance of an opposing tendency, so the absence of felt affliction is weak evidence of progress.

Their removal leads to isolation through a stated causal chain. Afflictions motivate action; action deposits a karmic store (**karmāśaya**) rooted in the afflictions; the store ripens as a threefold fruition (**vipāka**) of birth (**jāti**), life-span (**āyus**) and experience (**bhoga**); and that experience generates fresh reaction, closing the loop in renewed birth. Because the first link is psychological, the engine can be jammed at its source.

Yoga's therapy is graded accordingly. Preparatory discipline (**kriyā-yoga**) - austerity (**tapas**), self-study (**svādhyāya**) and dedication to the Lord (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**) - is prescribed expressly to attenuate the afflictions and prepare absorption. The eight-limbed discipline purifies conduct, embodiment and attention. Meditation burns the subtle forms of affliction that ethical restraint alone cannot reach. As the mind-field is purified, absorption stabilises and discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**) matures.

With higher dispassion (**para-vairāgya**) the practitioner ceases to crave even powers and exalted states, and cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**) rains down the fullness of discernment. Afflictions and binding action cease; the constituent qualities undergo involution (**pratiprasava**) for that witness; and consciousness abides in its own nature (**svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā**). This is isolation (**kaivalya**) - not union, not annihilation, but the ending of a misidentification whose machinery has been dismantled at the root.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2022, Question 5(c), 10 marks

Printed question. Discuss the nature and different stages of Samādhi as per Pātañjala yoga and examine the role of Īśvara in it.

Directive read. Two directives in one part: "discuss" the taxonomy, then "examine" the Lord's role - which requires a judgement about how far that role extends.

Model answer (189 words).

Absorption (**samādhi**) in Pātañjala Yoga is the highest refinement of attention, not passivity, and it is the threshold of liberating discernment. Object-supported absorption (**samprajñāta**) retains a support and is with-seed (**sabīja**); *Yoga-sūtra* 1.17 characterises it by deliberation, reflection, joy and bare I-am-ness, while *Yoga-sūtra* 1.42-1.44 separately classifies coalescence (**samāpatti**) as savitarkā and nirvitarkā for gross objects and savicārā and nirvicārā for subtle ones. The clarity of subtle coalescence yields truth-bearing insight (**ṛtambharā prajñā**). Supra-cognitive absorption (**asamprajñāta**) has impression-residue; when even that is restrained, absorption is seedless (**nirbīja**); cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**) is the culmination.

The Lord (**Īśvara**) is a special conscious witness (**puruṣa-viśeṣa**) untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit, denoted by the sacred syllable (**praṇava**). Dedication to him (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**) is a positive observance, a component of preparatory discipline and an independent means to absorption; it stabilises the mind-field and removes the nine obstacles (**antarāya**).

Examined strictly, however, his role is instrumental and not constitutive. He is neither material cause nor the Nyāya creator, and he does not bestow isolation; liberation still follows the practitioner's own discriminative discernment. Yoga's theism is therefore real but bounded - practice-enabling rather than creation-first.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023, Question 7(c), 15 marks

Printed question. Explain Citta and its modifications in the philosophy of Yoga. Why does Yoga philosophy prescribe cessation of modifications of Citta? Give reasons in support of your answer.

Directive read. Three demands in sequence: define the mind-field, list and explain the modifications, and supply reasons for cessation. The third demand is an argument, so it should be numbered.

Model answer (294 words).

The mind-field (**citta**) is the unified inner apparatus of determinative intellect (**buddhi**), ego-maker (**ahaṁkāra**) and sensory mind (**manas**). It is a product of primordial material nature and therefore insentient (**jaḍa**), yet as a working whole it is lucid-predominant and so transparent enough to take the form of objects and to mirror the conscious witness (**puruṣa**). It is the psychical instrument of experience, not the self.

A modification (**citta-vṛtti**) is any operative form the mind-field assumes. Patañjali classifies them exhaustively as five: valid cognition (**pramāṇa**) through perception, inference and authoritative testimony; error (**viparyaya**), as in taking nacre for silver; verbal construction (**vikalpa**), as in "the horn of a hare"; sleep (**nidrā**), a positive mode grounded on absence-content and evidenced by the waking report "I slept and knew nothing"; and memory (**smṛti**), the non-loss and re-presentation of experienced content. Each may be afflicted (**kliṣṭa**) or unafflicted (**akliṣṭa**).

Cessation is prescribed for five connected reasons. First, the mind-field by nature takes the form of whatever it attends to. Second, the witness's consciousness is reflected in that form. Third, in the absence of discriminative knowledge the changing form is appropriated in the first person - "I know", "I suffer", "I desire", "I remember". Fourth, the stream of modifications is therefore not a symptom of bondage but its running mechanism. Fifth, restraining the stream uncovers the already-free nature of the seer, as a pool reflects the sky faithfully once its ripples settle.

Two qualifications complete the answer. Restraint (**nirodha**) is revelatory rather than destructive: it removes concealment, not consciousness, and does not annihilate the mind as a substance. And valid cognition is included among the modifications deliberately, because what binds the seer is not the falsity of a mental form but the fact that it is a form at all.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024, Question 7(b), 15 marks

Printed question. "So long as there are changes and modifications in citta, the self is reflected therein, and, in the absence of discriminative knowledge, identifies itself with them." Present an appraisal of Yoga Soteriology in the light of the above statement.

Directive read. "Appraisal" is evaluative. The statement must first be unpacked doctrinally, then weighed - strengths, weaknesses and what remains contested.

Model answer (286 words).

The quoted statement compresses Yoga's entire diagnosis. The mind-field really changes, since Yoga inherits real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**) and recognises transformations of restraint, absorption and one-pointedness in a persisting substrate. Because the mind-field is lucid-predominant and transparent, the witness's light is reflected in it (**pratibimba**); and because the relation is mere proximity (**sannidhi-mātra**), the whole transformation occurs on the mind's side while the witness remains unchanged (**aparīṇāmin**). Where discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**) is absent, the borrowed light is read as the mind's own and the witness's witnesshood is read as agency - the conflation named egoity (**asmitā**).

Appraised positively, the soteriology is strong. It supplies a rigorous phenomenology of mental process - modification, memory, sleep, impression, affliction, absorption. It integrates psychology, ethics and metaphysics, since restraints, moral causation and mental restraint form one system. It offers an operational path rather than speculation: practice and dispassion, preparatory discipline, the eight limbs and graded absorption. And the isolation chapter's realist arguments against consciousness-only idealism show genuine metaphysical commitment.

The weaknesses are equally locatable. Mere proximity names the relation between an inactive witness and an active nature more clearly than it explains it, and Advaita and Nyāya press exactly there. The Lord's explanatory role is limited: he aids practice but is neither creator nor material cause nor the giver of isolation. And the value of contentless pure consciousness can be questioned by schools that define fulfilment through knowledge, relation, bliss or activity.

Two matters remain genuinely contested: the commentarial status of joy and I-am-ness within the absorption taxonomy, and whether isolation is austere aloneness or blissful self-abidance. The balanced verdict is that Yoga's account of how bondage operates is more secure than its account of how the two principles are related at all.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2025, Question 7(b), 15 marks

Printed question. Explain the nature of God and its role in Kaivalya in yoga philosophy.

Directive read. "Explain the nature of God and its role" requires the definition first and then a precise statement of how far that role extends - including what it does not do.

Model answer (263 words).

Yoga defines the Lord (**Īśvara**) as a special conscious witness (**puruṣa-viśeṣa**) untouched by affliction (**kleśa**), action (**karma**), fruition (**vipāka**) and karmic deposit (**āśaya**). In him lies the unsurpassed seed of omniscience; he is the teacher even of the ancients, being unconditioned by time; and he is denoted by the sacred syllable (**praṇava**, OM), whose repetition with contemplation of its meaning is a canonical practice. He is special, not different in kind: he belongs to the category of conscious witness, and his distinction is that he was never entangled. This admission is what makes Yoga theistic Sāṃkhya (**seśvara-sāṃkhya**) against Sāṃkhya's Godless tendency.

His positive roles are five: object of meditation, aid through dedication (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**), remover of the nine obstacles (**antarāya**), perfect model of untouched status, and timeless teacher-principle anchoring transmission.

His role in isolation (**kaivalya**) must be stated with precision. Isolation is the aloneness of the witness from primordial nature and its evolutes, reached through discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**), matured by higher dispassion (**para-vairāgya**) and consummated in cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**), after which the constituent qualities undergo involution (**pratiprasava**) and consciousness abides in its own nature. The Lord assists this process by stabilising the mind-field and clearing obstacles, but he does not grant isolation as an external gift.

Four negations therefore complete the answer: he is not the material cause; he is not the Nyāya creator and efficient cause of the world-order; he is not a saviour who bestows liberation arbitrarily; and he is not a substitute for discernment. The exact formula is that the Lord is **instrumental, not constitutive**, in liberation - not redundant, but

non-final.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2018, Question 6(a), 20 marks (routed; primary owner Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika)

Printed question. How do the Naiyāyikas prove the existence of God? Do the Yoga philosophers prove God in the same way? If yes, how? And if no, why? Give reasons for your answer.

Why it is solved here. The comparison is the question's subject, and its second half is entirely Yoga-owned material. The Nyāya half is summarised only as far as the comparison requires; the full Nyāya proof-set belongs to its own owner.

Model answer (383 words).

The Naiyāyikas argue for God as the efficient cause (**nimitta-kāraṇa**) of the world-order. Their proofs are inferential and cosmological in character: effects such as the composite world require an intelligent maker; atoms, being unintelligent, cannot combine without an intelligent director; the moral order requires an administrator who dispenses the fruits of action, since unseen merit cannot by itself allot results; the authority of scripture requires a trustworthy author; and the gradation of knowledge and power terminates in an omniscient and omnipotent being. Later Nyāya develops these into a systematic set of inferences to a creator who is efficient but not material cause.

Yoga does not prove God in this way, and the difference is structural rather than incidental. Patañjali's own grounds are compact and practice-facing. The Lord (**Īśvara**) is defined as a special conscious witness (**puruṣa-viśeṣa**) untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit; in him lies the unsurpassed seed of omniscience; he is the teacher of the ancients, unlimited by time; and he is denoted by the sacred syllable (**praṇava**), through which he becomes a contemplative support. These are characterisations of a being fit to be meditated upon, not inferences from the world to its maker.

The reasons for the divergence are three. First, ontology: Yoga inherits Sāṃkhya's dualism, in which primordial material nature (**prakṛti**) is the material basis of all evolution, so no creator is required to explain the world's arising. Second, method: Yoga's problem is practical - minds cannot hold still, obstacles derail practice, the ego resists surrender - and a never-entangled conscious witness is the most effective object such a mind can take. Third, soteriology: liberation follows discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**), so the Lord is instrumental rather than constitutive and cannot be argued for as the necessary cause of release.

A source caution belongs here. Later Yoga commentators do add more theoretical arguments - from scripture, from maximal degrees of knowledge and power, and from the need for intelligent coordination of witness and nature - and these move closer to Nyāya's style. But the full creator-and-administrator proof-set should not be projected back onto Patañjali.

The verdict: both schools are theistic and both are realist, but Nyāya's God is proved as the world's efficient cause and moral governor, while Yoga's Lord is described as a uniquely free witness and employed as an unequalled aid to concentration.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

These six questions are written in the style and directive-vocabulary of the paper. They are original practice items, not previous-year questions.

Original 1 - 10 marks

Question. Explain why Yoga includes valid cognition among the modifications of citta that must be restrained. Answer in about 175 words.

Model answer (168 words).

Yoga classifies all mental events into five modifications, and valid cognition (**pramāṇa**) - through perception, inference and authoritative testimony - is listed first. Its inclusion is deliberate, not careless.

The school's diagnosis is that the conscious witness (**puruṣa**) is misidentified with the forms the mind-field assumes. What binds is therefore *form*, not falsity. A true cognition is an accurate form and remains a form; the witness can appropriate it exactly as it appropriates an error, saying "I know" with the same misplaced first person.

Yoga nevertheless does not abolish cognition at once. Any modification may be afflicted (**kliṣṭa**) or unafflicted (**akliṣṭa**), and unafflicted valid cognition - of impermanence, of the distinction between witness and nature - is therapeutically indispensable. Even truth-bearing insight (**ṛtambharā prajñā**) works by producing an impression that blocks lower impressions.

But a ladder is climbed and left behind. When the unafflicted modification has done its work, it too must subside; and when even its impression is restrained, absorption becomes seedless. Restraint is thus revelatory, not a devaluation of truth.

Original 2 - 10 marks

Question. Discuss the significance of the claim that abhiniveśa is present even in the learned. Answer in about 175 words.

Model answer (168 words).

Clinging to life (**abhiniveśa**) is the fifth affliction, ordinarily expressed as fear of death. Yoga adds that it is found even in the learned, and this qualification carries substantial doctrinal weight.

First, it establishes that afflictions are not beliefs. If clinging were an intellectual error, instruction would remove it. Its survival in the learned shows that it is carried by impressions (**saṃskāra**) and latent tendencies (**vāsanā**) rather than by opinions.

Second, it justifies Yoga's method against a purely argumentative rival. If discriminative knowledge could be produced by exposition alone, the eight-limbed discipline would be superfluous. The claim therefore explains why Yoga is *Sāṃkhya made trainable*.

Third, it explains the four states of affliction. A learned person may report no fear, yet the affliction may be dormant (**prasupta**) or merely interrupted (**vicchinna**) by a stronger tendency; only meditative burning of the subtle form and finally discriminative discernment destroy the seed.

The claim thus links Yoga's psychology, its method and its critique of merely doctrinal knowledge in a single observation.

Original 3 - 15 marks

Question. Examine the view that Yoga's reflection theory succeeds as phenomenology but not as metaphysics. Answer in about 275 words.

Model answer (275 words).

Yoga's reflection theory holds that the mind-field (**citta**), being lucid-predominant and transparent though insentient (**jaḍa**), mirrors the light of the conscious witness (**puruṣa**), while the witness, being unchanging (**aparīṇāmin**), remains untouched. The resulting conflation of the seer's power with the instrument's power is egoity (**asmitā**), and the relation is described as mere proximity (**sannidhi-mātra**).

As phenomenology the theory is impressive. It explains the unity of an experience that seems to have a single conscious owner while its components are distributed across an object, a mental modification and a witness. It explains why bondage feels total and why liberation can nevertheless be described as a correction rather than a rescue. It generates a workable therapy, since the misreading occurs in the instrument and the instrument can be disciplined. And it supplies exact analogies - the crystal coloured by a nearby flower, the magnet moving iron by presence alone.

As metaphysics it is more exposed. Reflection normally presupposes some real relation between mirror and original; if the two principles are ontologically disjoint, the relation is precisely what has not been explained. Saying that all transformation occurs on the mind's side protects the witness but relocates rather than answers the difficulty. Advaita presses by collapsing the duality into one consciousness; Nyāya presses by making consciousness an adventitious property of a substantial self; and the isolation chapter's own realist argument, that an object is known when the mind is coloured by it, reproduces the same puzzle at the object-end.

The examined verdict is therefore that mere proximity names the relation more clearly than it explains it - which is a real limitation, though not a refutation of the phenomenology it protects.

Original 4 - 15 marks

Question. Distinguish clearly between the two classifications of samādhi in the Samādhi-pāda, and explain why their conflation damages an answer. Answer in about 275 words.

Model answer (255 words).

The absorption chapter uses two classifications, applied to one meditative ascent by different criteria.

The first, at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.17, characterises object-supported absorption (**samprajñāta**) by four accompanying factors: gross deliberation (**vitarka**), subtle reflection (**vicāra**), refined lucid joy (**ānanda**) and bare I-am-ness (**asmitā**). Two of these require protection: the joy is a purified meditative affect attached to the lucid quality, not ordinary pleasure; and the I-am-ness is not the binding affliction but an extremely subtle objectification of the I-sense.

The second, at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.42-1.44, classifies coalescence (**samāpatti**) by object-level and by conceptual-verbal overlay: savitarkā and nirvitarkā for gross (**sthūla**) objects, savicārā and nirvicārā for subtle (**sūkṣma**) objects, the *nir*-members being purified of the word-object-knowledge construction. *Yoga-sūtra* 1.45 extends the subtle domain to the undifferentiated (**aliṅga**), and 1.46 declares all of these with-seed (**sabīja**).

Conflation damages an answer in three ways. Factually, it produces the false sentence that Patañjali lists savitarka, nirvitarka, savicāra and nirvicāra as the four kinds of object-supported absorption, when the sūtra's own fourfold characterisation is different. Structurally, it destroys the distinction between *what accompanies* an absorption and *what it rests on*, which is the very distinction a question on stages is testing. Consequentially, it obscures the terminological trap around "seed": with-seed at 1.46 means with object-support, whereas seedless (**nirbīja**) at 1.51 means without the residual impression, so losing an object-support does not by itself make an absorption seedless.

The safe formulation is that commentators *map* the two grids without identifying them, and that the mapping of joy and I-am-ness remains commentarily disputed.

Original 5 - 20 marks

Question. Critically examine the claim that Yoga is merely a practical discipline built on a borrowed metaphysics. Answer in about 375 words.

Model answer (345 words).

The claim has an obvious basis. Yoga accepts Sāṃkhya's dualism of conscious witness (**puruṣa**) and primordial material nature (**prakṛti**), the three constituent qualities, the twenty-five principles (**tattva**), real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**) and liberation by discrimination. It re-argues none of these. The tradition's own labels - Sāṃkhya-exposition and theistic Sāṃkhya (**seśvara-sāṃkhya**) - record the debt openly.

Three considerations nonetheless defeat the word "merely".

First, Yoga owns a substantial body of doctrine. The mind-field (**citta**) as a unified apparatus, the fivefold classification of modifications, the afflicted and unafflicted division, the five afflictions with their four states, the moral causation of action and fruition, the eight-limbed discipline, the two absorption taxonomies, truth-bearing insight, cloud-of-dharma absorption and isolation are not restatements of Sāṃkhya but Yoga's own subject matter.

Second, Yoga is metaphysically committed in its own right. The isolation chapter contains a genuine realist polemic against consciousness-only idealism: an object is not dependent on a single mind, since it would otherwise vanish when unattended; the mind is not self-illuminating because it is itself something seen for the witness; the mind cannot be both lamp and illuminated object in one act; and knowledge occurs when the mind is coloured (**uparakta**) by an object standing outside the cognition. A praxis manual does not argue like this.

Third, the admission of the Lord (**Īśvara**) is a doctrinal difference, not decoration. A special conscious witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit changes the psychological and devotional resources of the path, even though the ontology stays dualist.

The critical qualifications must nevertheless be conceded. Yoga adds nothing to the account of what ultimately exists; its Lord is explanatorily limited, being neither material cause nor creator nor the giver of isolation; and it inherits, unresolved, the interaction problem between an inactive witness and an active nature.

The examined verdict is therefore that Yoga is not derivative but complementary. Sāṃkhya supplies the metaphysical grammar; Yoga turns it into a disciplined technology of liberation with a subtle moral psychology, a graded meditative epistemology and a defended realism - while remaining vulnerable at exactly the joint its parent school left open.

Original 6 - 20 marks

Question. Analyse the causal mechanism by which Yoga claims that disciplined attention can end rebirth, and assess how far the claim is defensible. Answer in about 375 words.

Model answer (360 words).

Yoga's claim depends on a chain whose first link is psychological. The afflictions (**kleśa**) - ignorance, egoity, attachment, aversion and clinging to life - motivate action; action deposits a karmic store (**karmāśaya**) that is rooted in the afflictions (**kleśa-mūla**); that store ripens as a threefold fruition (**vipāka**) of birth (**jāti**), life-span (**āyus**) and experience (**bhoga**); and the experience generates fresh reaction, closing the loop. Continuity is carried by impressions (**saṃskāra**) and latent tendencies (**vāsanā**), which is why the cycle is self-reinforcing rather than merely repetitive.

The intervention follows from the structure. Because action binds by being coloured, the target is the colouring rather than the acting - which is what the fourfold classification of action as white, black, mixed and neither-white-nor-black records. Preparatory discipline (**kriyā-yoga**) attenuates the afflictions; the eight limbs remove gross disturbance in conduct, embodiment and sense; meditation burns subtle forms that ethical restraint cannot reach; absorption stabilises; and discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**) destroys the seed. Cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**) marks the end of afflictions and binding action, after which the constituent qualities undergo involution (**pratiprasava**) for that witness.

The transformation-doctrine supplies the missing premise: the mind-field really changes across practice, in transformations of restraint, absorption and one-pointedness, upon a persisting substrate (**dharmīn**). Without a bearer, accumulation and graded acquisition would be unintelligible.

How far is this defensible? Internally it is coherent and unusually well-integrated: psychology, ethics and soteriology are one system, and the burnt-seed image answers the scale objection by distinguishing seeds of future bondage from an already-moving momentum, as a potter's wheel turns after the push stops.

The pressures are three. The Buddhist momentarist can reconstruct continuity through a causal series without a substrate, so the persisting mind is a postulate rather than a demonstration. The witness-nature relation remains named as mere proximity rather than explained. And the whole chain presupposes a morally ordered cosmos in which subtle mental causes ripen beyond a single episode of experience - a presupposition the Cārvāka denies and Yoga can defend only by appeal to disciplined extraordinary perception, which is not publicly checkable.

The assessment: the mechanism is impressively economical given its premises, and it is those premises rather than the mechanism that remain contestable.